

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 3 (Teaching Week 3): The state — where do states come from?

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Tuesday 29 September 2026

The state

A line on a map where if you're inside it, it can tax you, draft you, and lock you up!

...and mostly, you let it



Last time, and today

- **Lecture 2** asked *what is power* and introduced the three faces of power
- **Today: the state.** What is it, and where did it come from?
- **Next time:** fine, we have states, but why can some *do* things, and others can't?

Okay. So what *is* a state?

You've never lived a day without one. Could you actually define it?

We usually say “the government” or “the country”...not quite right.

The weird thing we're explaining

What a state actually **is**, stripped of familiarity:

- A line on a map, mostly agreed on, rarely moved by force
- An organisation that can **tax** you, **conscript** you, **jail** you
- Almost everyone, almost all the time, just goes along with it
- It does all of this to millions of people it has never “met”

Why does *this* exist? Why would anyone let an organisation have that much reach over them?

Two (unsatisfying?) answers today:

- because war built it
- because life without one would probably be worse

Weber's answer

The state: a human community that successfully claims the ***monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force*** within a given ***territory***.

— Max Weber, *Politics as a Vocation* (1919)

✨⭐ **monopoly on the legitimate use of force** ⭐🌟



What does each word actually rule out?

- **Monopoly:** not “mostly.” *The only one allowed to.*
 - A gang or a militia using force is breaking the state’s rule, not competing with it
- **Legitimate:** force people accept as *rightful*. Think back to authority and power on Friday
- **Territory:** a state’s authority holds *here* and stops *there*
 - A church or an employer can claim authority over you, but has no territory

Put together: the state isn’t defined by what it’s for, but by what it **controls**: legitimate force, in a bounded space.

Why do people accept the state's force as rightful?

Weber's answer is that legitimacy can come from three places:

- **Traditional:** “it has always been this way.” A king, a chief, a custom
- **Charismatic:** devotion to one extraordinary leader. You obey *the person*. (“L’etat c’est moi”)
- **Legal-rational:** you obey the rules and the office, whoever holds it

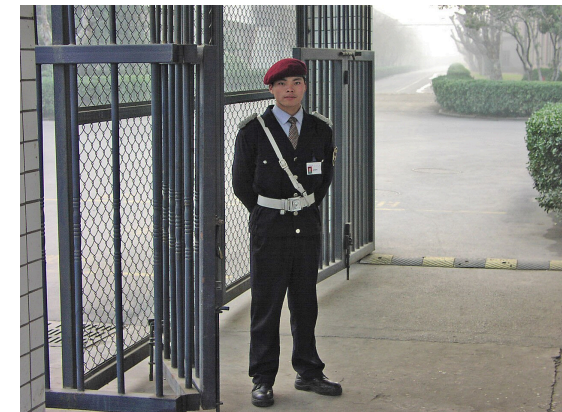
Most modern states run *mainly* on the third but actually mix all three.

A state with *none* of them has to fight for every street, every day. In this case, it's just the biggest gang in the fight

- Example: **Yemen** today

Which of these breaks the state's monopoly?

- A private security firm patrols a gated estate: force but no monopoly
- A cartel taxes a town's market stalls, and the police don't go there
- A paramilitary polices "its" community, and the state can't or won't stop it



How the three cases score on Weber's test

- **Security firm:** force used under the state's licence and law, which the state can revoke. Delegated force, not a rival
- **Cartel:** taken literally, the cartel is closer to holding the local monopoly than the state is. The state's writ has stopped running there
- **Paramilitary:** the monopoly is openly contested, in the name of a different claim to rule

That is the definition doing its job: tells you where state power actually stops

Weber's definition is a test for the messy cases – think about most countries' histories

Apply it to the state we're currently in

Treaty signed, December 1921. Irish Free State established, December 1922.

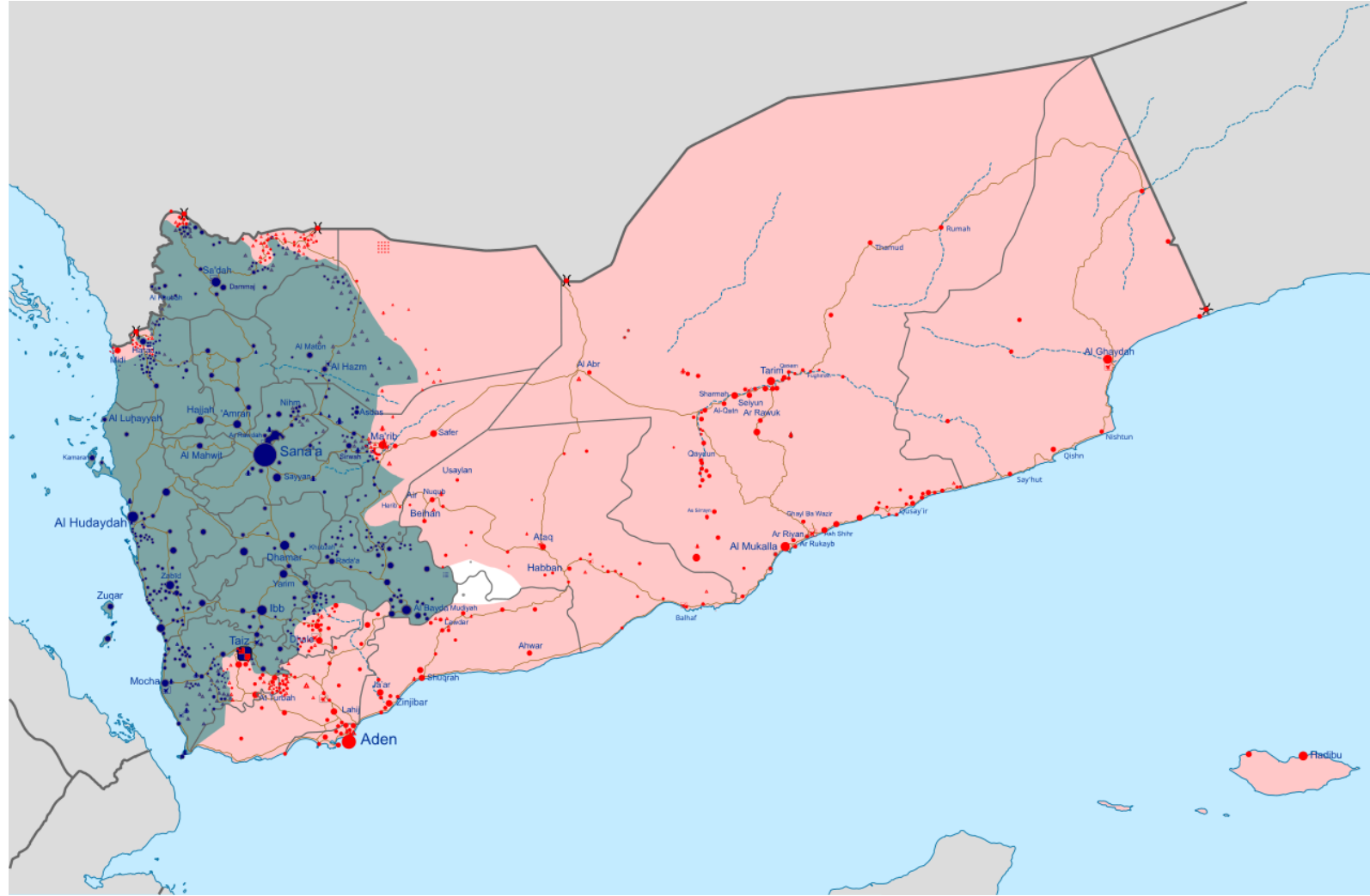
- June 1922 – May 1923: the new state fights a **civil war** against the anti-Treaty IRA, who denied its right to exist at all
- Ends not in surrender but in an order to “**dump arms**”: go home, keep the guns
- Decades later, paramilitaries were still claiming the right to use force in the name of an Irish republic

Weber's test: **the monopoly is something a state wins, loses, and has to keep winning.** Not something it gets at independence.



Yemen

- Nobody has held the monopoly since 2014
- **Houthis** (green): rebels who took the capital, Sanaa, and rule about 70% of Yemenis
- **Government** (pink): recognised abroad, propped up by Saudi Arabia, split into rivals
- **Sept 2026:** the Houthis take almost all of the Red Sea coast



Map: Ali Zifan and others, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0
(updated 19 September 2026)



**So is this “state” thing natural?
Where did it come from?**

What did people have instead?

For most of human history, “who’s in charge here” had a different answer:

- **Empires:** authority radiating out from a centre, thinning at the edges
- **City-states:** sovereignty, but tiny and local
- **Religious authorities:** e.g., in medieval Europe, the Roman Catholic Church had overlapping authority with kings

No one of these looked like a bounded territory with one monopoly on force. That shape had to be *built*.

Charles Tilly brings the heat

“War made the state, and the state made war.”
— Charles Tilly

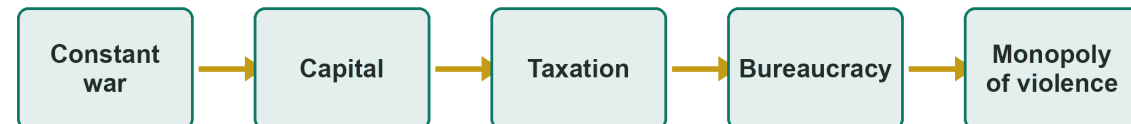


War → capital → taxes → bureaucracy

1. Rival rulers, competing for the same territory → **constant war**
2. War (guns, cannon, standing armies) needs **capital**
3. Capital requires **taxation**: knowing who your people are and what they have
4. Taxation and war both require **bureaucracy**
5. To make any of this stick, you need a **monopoly on violence**

Follow the chain back: the modern *bureaucratic* state was a **side effect of war-making**. Nobody designed it on purpose.*

* says Tilly!



Tilly's chain in Peter the Great's Russia

- **1700–1721:** twenty-one years of war with Sweden
- **1718:** to pay for the army, count every tax-paying male: peasants and townsmen, not nobles or clergy
- **1722–24:** a new “soul tax” on each of them, at first collected by the army itself
- **1717–22:** new ministries, and a Table of Ranks for officials that lasted until 1917



War, a census, a tax and a bureaucracy, all inside one reign

Does Tilly's story fit everywhere?

Tilly built his story almost entirely on **early modern Europe**: centuries of war forcing rulers to tax and count their people

The hard cases: most of **post-colonial Africa** got its borders from European negotiating tables, not from wars between rival states

One answer: the theory holds up. With land plentiful and borders guaranteed from outside, rulers rarely had to fight for territory, so few built the reach to govern all of it Herbst, *States and Power in Africa*, 2000

See you Friday

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science · Dr Noah Buckley · Trinity College Dublin · MT2026

Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.